Farmer Corn Brief

Week of October 22, 2026

> **Week of October 22, 2026**
> Nearby corn: $4.633/bu (-$0.147 (-3.1%) week)
> Narrative created: October 23, 2026

Nearby futures from Yahoo Finance. Nearby corn is the market's current perception of yield and demand risk.

Contract	Last	Week change	As of
Nearby corn	$4.633/bu	-$0.147 (-3.1%)	October 21, 2026
RBOB gasoline	$3.120/gal	-0.060 (-1.9%)	October 21, 2026
Henry Hub	$2.790/MMBtu	-0.446 (-13.8%)	October 21, 2026

Where we are

USDA's October balance sheet remains the controlling crop regime: **16.034 billion bushels at 181.2 bushels per acre**, with projected 2026/27 ending stocks of **1.849 billion bushels**. Nebraska remains at **188 bushels per acre and 1.807 billion bushels**. USDA raised beginning stocks, production and use in October, but supply increased more than disappearance. (USDA WAOB, *WASDE-676*, October 9, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Harvest delays have not overturned that larger-crop estimate. As of October 18, the United States was **44% harvested**, versus a 52% five-year average. Nebraska reached **37%**, up 10 points for the week but still behind the 48% average. Iowa was only 26% harvested versus 50% normally. (USDA NASS, *Crop Progress*, October 19, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

Nearby corn is December. The supplied tape closed October 21 at **$4.633 per bushel**, down **14.7 cents**, or **3.1%**, from October 15. March settled at **$4.7725**, leaving **14 cents of December-to-March**

carry. (DePutter Publishing/Syngenta, *Chicago Close: Wheat Down on Possible Russia-Ukraine Talks*, October 21, 2026) (syngenta.ca)

The week in one page

- **The market continued to accept USDA's larger crop.** Nearby December lost 14.7 cents to $4.633. A harvest lag in Nebraska and Iowa was not enough to rebuild the yield premium removed by the October report.
- **The board—not a new collapse in basis—did most of the cash-price damage.** Selected Nebraska processor bids fell about 21 cents from October 14 through Thursday morning, while their spot-versus-deferred schedules remained broadly similar: weak harvest bids and better December through March delivery bids.
- **Fourteen cents of December-to-March carry does not pay for automatic storage.** That is less than 5 cents per month before interest, shrink, handling and aeration. The bin needs basis improvement or a firm deferred cash contract.
- **Ethanol plants increased run time, but inventories increased faster.** Production rose to 1.094 million barrels per day, while stocks climbed roughly 600,000 barrels to 24.6 million. Plants are consuming corn, but the stock build does not require them to chase harvest bushels.
- **Export sales finally beat expectations.** Weekly sales reached 1.53 million metric tons, up 36%. That helps demand credibility, but one good week did not reverse the board's supply-driven decline.
- **Verdict:** This week made it harder to raise the average sale price. The board took away another 14.7 cents, while basis and carry offered only partial protection. Do not panic-sell weak basis, but protect rebounds and make storage show a return.

Exposure	Current signal	Change this week	Time horizon	Marketing read
Unpriced 2026 crop	December at $4.633	Down 14.7 cents	Immediate	Use rebounds or floors; do not wait solely for harvest delay
Stored old-crop	Larger carry-in and larger new crop	Board lower again	Immediate	Sell firm basis; avoid another routine roll

Exposure	Current signal	Change this week	Time horizon	Marketing read
Harvest basis	Spot generally weaker than deferred	Little broad improvement	Harvest–winter	Set futures separately where spot basis is poor
Storage	14-cent Dec–March carry	About ½ cent wider	Through March	Storage needs basis appreciation to cover costs
Ethanol bid	Stronger production, larger stocks	Mixed	Two to four weeks	Shop plants; no statewide chase signal

1. Harvest delays failed to rebuild the crop-risk premium

What happened

The prior week established a heavier supply regime. This week tested whether slow harvest and field uncertainty would challenge it. They did not.

National harvest remained eight points behind normal, and Nebraska fell eleven points behind. Nebraska producers reported 5.2 suitable fieldwork days, down from 6.3 the previous week. Even so, December corn fell 14.7 cents. (USDA NASS, *Crop Progress*, October 19, 2026) (esmis.nal.usda.gov)

The tape is the consistency check. The market currently views delayed harvest as a logistics issue, not enough evidence that USDA's **181.2-bushel yield** is wrong.

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

A slower combine pace can briefly support an individual elevator or ethanol-plant bid. It does not necessarily tighten the national balance sheet. This week, the board discounted the delay and stayed focused on 16.034 billion bushels of production and 1.849 billion of carryout.

What to do with it

2026 crop: Re-size bushels from actual combine results. Do not make a broad panic futures sale after a 15-cent break. Do not remain fully open waiting for delayed harvest to force $5 corn either. Treat recoveries as opportunities to protect more confirmed production.

Stored old-crop: The harvest delay is not a reason to keep carrying 2025 bushels. Sell firm basis and stop competing with the larger new crop.

Watch next

The November 10 Crop Production and WASDE reports must lower yield or acreage materially before the smaller-crop argument regains control.

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2. Cash prices followed the board lower; deferred basis still does more work

What happened

Thursday morning processor sheets showed ADM Columbus at **$4.30 nearby, $4.55 for December and $4.61 for March**. Cargill Blair was **$4.35 nearby, $4.50 for December and $4.65 for March**. Green Plains Central City was **$4.33 nearby, $4.45 for December and $4.58 for March**. (Farmbucks, *CVA Nebraska Cash Bids*, updated October 22, 2026) (farmbucks.com)

Those nearby and December bids were generally about **21 cents lower** than the same posted locations on October 14. The size and uniformity of the drop indicate that the board caused most of the loss; buyers did not broadly strengthen basis to cushion it.

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

Harvest basis remains poor enough to separate futures from basis. Yet the gross cash spread from nearby delivery to March is roughly 25 to 30 cents at the stronger processors. About 14 cents comes from the board. The rest is the buyer paying better basis later.

What to do with it

On the combine: Reward a delivery special or strong feed bid. At weak spot basis, an HTA, short hedge or firm deferred basis contract may preserve more value than an immediate cash sale.

In the bin: Do not leave futures, basis and storage costs all open without a target. Fourteen cents of board carry alone is not enough. Make the deferred cash bid cover interest, shrink and handling.

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3. Ethanol plants ran harder, but the stock build limits bid urgency

What happened

U.S. ethanol production rose **29,000 barrels per day** to **1.094 million**, a 2.7% increase. Midwest production rose 23,000 barrels per day to **1.033 million**. (EIA, *Weekly Ethanol Plant Production*, October 21, 2026) (eia.gov)

Ethanol inventories increased from 23.9 million to **24.6 million barrels**, including a roughly 500,000-barrel Midwest build. RBOB gasoline also lost 6 cents per gallon during the reporting week. (EIA, *Weekly Petroleum Status Report—Table 5*, October 21, 2026) (eia.gov)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

The stronger run rate is real corn disappearance and supports the ethanol plant as a dependable local buyer. The inventory build says production exceeded near-term disappearance. That helps explain why stronger plant demand did not translate into broadly stronger Nebraska basis.

What to do with it

Shop plants, especially for December through March delivery. Sell firm basis when offered. Do not assume a 1.094-million-barrel run rate guarantees a better bid if stocks continue building.

Watch next

Two more weeks of strong production with stable or declining stocks would improve the local-bid case. Continued stock builds would keep buyers patient.

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4. Export sales improved enough to help, not enough to change the board

What happened

Corn export sales for 2026/27 reached **1.53 million metric tons** for the week ended October 15, up 36% and slightly above the top of published trade expectations. (USDA FAS, *Weekly Export Sales*,

October 22, 2026; Dow Jones, *U.S. Soybean Export Sales See Big Weekly Rise*, October 22, 2026.) (fas-prod.azureedge.us)

Estimated cumulative commitments are now near **22.2 million metric tons**, or roughly **874 million bushels**. That is about 26% of USDA's **3.300-billion-bushel** export forecast. Commitments remain behind last year even after the improved week. (businessquant.com)

Why it matters for a long-corn producer

Demand is not disappearing. It is also not growing fast enough yet to make the market disregard a 16-billion-bushel crop. The board's weekly loss confirms that stronger sales were supporting evidence, not the controlling price signal.

What to do with it

Use export-driven bounces as pricing opportunities. Do not base storage or an unpriced position on the assumption that one strong sales week will erase the October supply increase.

The crop you still have to market

Stored 2025 corn: Clear firm basis. Larger beginning stocks, a larger 2026 crop and modest carry leave little reason to keep paying ownership costs without a contracted return.

2026 corn: Avoid dumping weak harvest basis after the board break. Protect futures on rebounds or use a floor if another decline would put breakeven out of reach. Lock firm deferred basis where the buyer—not your bin—is paying the storage return.

The running December average used for the RP harvest price was approximately **$4.84 through October 21**, still **22 cents above the $4.62 projected price**, with six discovery days remaining. That can help an insured yield loss. It does not replace a sale on normal-yield bushels. (Barchart, *Corn Futures Recovering on Thursday Morning*, October 22, 2026; farmdoc, *Projected Prices and Volatility Factors for 2026*, March 3, 2026.) (tateandlyle.websol.barchart.com)

Bottom line

The new information was not another USDA revision. It was the market's verdict on the October revision: **December lost another 14.7 cents even with harvest behind schedule**.

Do not give away weak spot basis. Do not store for 14 cents of carry alone. Protect rebounds, favor firm deferred basis over open-ended bin ownership, and make the November 10 USDA report prove the crop is smaller before rebuilding a bullish position.